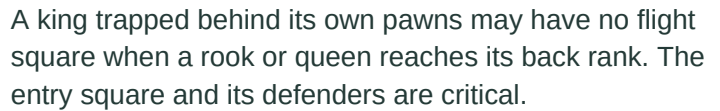


Back-rank mates

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES



Inspect the king's pawn shelter, then find how a heavy piece can enter the last rank or remove its defender.

The defending king is on c8. Geometrically undefended: rook on h8 and knight on c3. Check for tactical protection.

Previous move: 19...Nxc3. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

20. Re8+ Rd8 21. Be6+ Kb8 22. Rxd8#

20.Re8+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. From e8 it attacks king on c8 and bishop on f8. Recorded reply: **20...Rd8**.

21.Be6+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. Recorded reply: **21...Kb8**.

22.Rxd8# Mate: rook on d8 gives check; Black has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on b8. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Rook on d8. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

A flight square, an interposition, or a countercheck may refute an apparent mate. Check all three before sacrificing material.